

The Crisis of Empire, 1895-1914: The Boer War and its Consequences

The climax of all the imperial excitement of the late-nineteenth century was reached during the Anglo-Boer War. A 'mighty' British imperial army (which at one stage numbered 450,000 men) faced a Boer army of less than 100,000 independent farmers, who lacked training, ammunition, supplies and long-range weapons. To defeat them the British army burned farms, crops, and villages, divided the countryside into zones with barbed wire fences, and captured soldiers, women and children and placed them in concentration camps. The war began in 1899 and ended in 1902. When it was all over 22,000 British lives had been lost, £250 million pounds had been spent, and over 20,000 South Africans had perished in the concentration camps. Britain had suffered international humiliation. 'Britain's Vietnam' is how one historian describes the South African War. The Boer War was a deeply significant event in the history of the Empire from 1815 to 1914, with far reaching consequences.

1 The Road to War, 1895-9

The immediate cause of the war revolved around an argument between Britain and the Transvaal over voting rights for European immigrants employed in gold and diamond mines in South Africa. The British government wanted the independent Boer republic to grant full citizenship rights to these 41,000 strong, mainly British, immigrant 'Uitlanders' (outsiders). Paul Kruger, the Transvaal President, believed the Uitlander issue was being used by the British government as a way of ending the independence of the Boer Republics. If the Uitlanders had been given full voting rights they would have eventually grown strong enough to elect a government of their own choosing. This was a prospect the fiercely independent Boers would not contemplate. Throughout the crisis, Kruger retained the conviction that the British government would not compromise over the issue.

The Uitlander dispute was really the final straw in a long-standing Anglo-Boer antagonism. In the late-seventeenth century the Dutch East India Company had set up a small trading station near the Cape of Good Hope on the southern tip of South Africa (Cape Colony). The poorest members of this deeply Protestant community were grazing farmers who called themselves *treboers* (also known as Boers) and searched for land, at the expense of Africans. The Boers viewed themselves as a distinct and unique group of pilgrims, called themselves 'Afrikanders' (the

people of Africa), spoke a variant of Dutch they called 'Afrikaans', and were hostile to both Africans and Europeans.

In 1806 the British navy captured Cape Colony. Henceforth, the Cape of Good Hope became a crucial naval base for Britain on the trade route to India and the Far East. In 1834 the British abolished slavery. A group of 5,000 Boers refused to accept the decision, crossed the Orange and Vaal rivers on the 'great trek', and set up two independent states (Transvaal and the Orange Free State). These 'Boer Republics' enshrined their unique Protestant identity and language in their constitutions. The Boers were determined to exclude Africans (and anyone else) from voting in their elections.

By 1855 the British government had recognised the independence of these two countries. But this did not stop Anglo-Boer relations remaining tense. In 1877 Britain took control of the Transvaal (over the Zulu threat). In 1881 Paul Kruger (Transvaal President) attacked the British (First Boer War) because they refused to restore independence to the Boer Republic after the Zulu war. After a Boer victory over the British at Majuba Hill the British government decided to restore partial independence. This was done under two agreements signed in 1882 and 1884. But the treaties contained two provisos. Firstly, Britain supervised foreign policy, and secondly, the British retained the right to intervene, in certain circumstances, in domestic matters. The dispute between the Transvaal and the British government over the Uitlander issue revolved around the interpretation of the wording of the agreements that followed the first Anglo-Boer war.

In addition to the disagreement over the extent of British rights in the Transvaal, there was an underlying economic dimension to the dispute. In the late-nineteenth century gold and diamonds were discovered in Cape Colony and the Transvaal. This 'mineral revolution' transformed the economic balance in the region. The Transvaal suddenly changed from being a backward agricultural economy into a country which was rapidly increasing in prosperity and which threatened to dominate the British colonies in South Africa. However, much of the Transvaal's new wealth was in the hands of British and German gold and diamond mineowners ('Rand millionaires') who had established mines in the area, having attracted large amounts of British investment.

The economic role played by the 'Rand millionaires' in the origins of the war has been the subject of historical controversy ever since. It appears that the major mineowners did support the Uitlanders' claims for voting rights, primarily, it seems, because they believed that it would be difficult to attract British and European skilled workers to an area in which they were denied basic civil rights. The obstinacy that the Transvaal government showed towards the Uitlanders was viewed as a severe handicap in the continuing effort to attract labour and investment, both of which were vital for long-term expansion. Therefore, the 'Rand millionaires' felt that they stood to profit from an

extension of voting rights to the Uitlanders. Indeed J.A. Hobson claimed that the war was caused by a 'conspiracy of financiers' for whom the Uitlander issue was a cloak to hide a desire for private profit. This view was supported by Thomas Pakenham in *The Boer War* (1979) who claimed that leading mineowners 'were active partners' with Lord Milner in the making of the war. This probably overstates the case. In his brilliant study, *The Origins of the South African War* (1983), Andrew Porter claimed that 'the British government was tightening the screws on the Transvaal from 1895', but he rejected the view that it was the puppet of the mining magnates. Cain and Hopkins added weight to this argument by asserting that the British government and the Colonial Office were leading the drive to place pressure on the Transvaal in support of broader strategic, political and economic aims which included (but was not dominated by) the desires of the mineowners.

The roles played by Joseph Chamberlain, the Colonial Secretary, and Sir Alfred Milner, British High Commissioner for South Africa, remain the most vital elements in explaining why Britain went to war. Both Chamberlain and Milner did express concerns about the dangers for British interests in Southern Africa of a vibrant and independent Transvaal seemingly determined to cause difficulties for British interests in the region.

For his part, Joseph Chamberlain soured Anglo-Boer relations in the run up to war in three ways. Firstly, he informed Kruger that the agreements Britain had signed at the end of the First Boer War had not -- as the Transvaal government believed -- restored full control over domestic policy to the Republic. Secondly, he appointed Alfred Milner, a man who was known to be hostile to the Transvaal, as High Commissioner for South Africa. Thirdly, he successfully encouraged the City of London to deny the Transvaal loans for long-term investment. Yet whether Chamberlain did all this as part of a deliberate plan to instigate a war with the Boer Republics remains open to question. It appears he wanted the Transvaal to accede to British demands on behalf of the Uitlanders, short of going to war. No convincing evidence has yet emerged to prove that he wanted war all along.

The leading candidate for 'warmonger' is Alfred Milner, the British High Commissioner for South Africa. Milner had his finger in every pie. He placed enormous pressure on the Transvaal government in the run up to the war. He constantly pressed the Uitlander issue, whipped up anti-Boer feeling in the South African and British press, put pressure on the City of London to deny the Transvaal capital, gained support from the 'Rand millionaires' and persuaded many leading figures in the Unionist government to support him. Milner was convinced there was a 'greater issue than the grievances of the Uitlanders at stake ... our supremacy in South Africa ... and our existence as a great power in the world is involved'.

Milner also personally conducted the negotiations with the Transvaal

government. In all his dealings with Kruger he took an aggressive and uncompromising stance. He demanded that the Uitlanders be granted full citizenship of the Transvaal within five years. In May 1899 Kruger met him in a final attempt to settle the dispute. At the meeting Kruger offered the Uitlanders full citizenship within seven years in return for British recognition of the independence of the Transvaal in domestic matters, and he expressed a willingness to discuss all outstanding issues at an international conference in Europe. Milner rejected both offers point blank. Kruger's response that 'it is our country you want' would seem an accurate reflection of the situation.

It seems clear that 'Milner stirred the pot' and pushed everyone to the brink of war. Yet few historians are now prepared to suggest that he was deliberately planning to achieve his aims by war. It appears that Milner, and most of his supporters, believed Kruger would 'bluff up to the canon's mouth' and would then accept British demands. The failure of the Cabinet, Milner, the Colonial Office and War Office to make adequate preparation for an armed struggle certainly adds weight to this interpretation. It seems that the long-term economic growth of the Transvaal, which was likely to turn it into the major power in Southern Africa, led to a fundamental conflict of interests between Britain and the Republic. As Cain and Hopkins put it, 'Milner helped to stir the pot. He did not supply the ingredients. More important were the British government and, indirectly, the mine owners'.

By the autumn of 1899 Chamberlain, the Cabinet, the majority of MPs and the press had all swung around to Milner's earlier view that the Boers needed 'teaching a lesson'. British troops were sent to South Africa to exert the final pressure on Kruger. The Boers were now left with two choices. They could either accept British demands or they could fight for their independence. They chose the latter option. On 9 October 1899 Kruger sent a telegram demanding Britain remove its troops from the Transvaal border or he would declare war. At the same time he offered to settle the matter at an international conference. The British government did not even reply. On 11 October the Transvaal (much to the surprise of Milner) launched the attack on Cape Colony which started the Boer War. On hearing this news Lord Salisbury, the British Prime Minister, said, 'this has relieved us of the task of explaining to the British public why we are at war'. The full weight of the 'mighty' British Empire was now ranged against a mainly farming community. The general view in Britain was that 'it will all be over by Christmas'.

There remains one question to be answered in examining the causes of the war. Why did Kruger decide to fight? It appears that he never believed that the British were bluffing. He was absolutely convinced (especially after the Jameson Raid) that the British wanted to end the independence of the Transvaal. Once this seemed clear, Kruger was determined that the Boers would fight. The Transvaal government never did want to concede voting rights to the Uitlanders. In the 1890s

arms had been purchased from Germany in preparation for a war which Kruger and most of his supporters saw as 'inevitable'. Kruger's resolve was stiffened by the leading Boer generals (especially Smuts) who constantly advised the President that if war came the British could be defeated. Kruger also knew that he could rely completely on Boer farmers to fight bravely to preserve their independence. A large number of Boers did believe a war with Britain might end up with the same result as the American War of Independence - a United States of Southern Africa under the leadership of the Transvaal. It seems that the Transvaal was more determined (and better prepared) to fight than Milner had anticipated.

2 The Course of the War, 1899-1902

In the early months of the war Britain suffered a series of humiliating defeats at the hands of the Boers who laid siege to the towns of Ladysmith, Kimberly and Mafeking. In one 'black week' in December 1899 the British lost battles at Stromberg, Magersfontein and Colenso. In January 1900 a further British defeat occurred at Spion Kop.

These early setbacks shook British confidence. They were the result of poor planning by the War Office and poor leadership by the generals. The British underestimated the Boers and had failed to ensure that adequate troops and essential supplies of food and ammunition were in place ready for the conflict. The solution was to send more troops, to improve supply lines, and to dispatch Lord Roberts ('hero of the Indian Mutiny') and Lord Kitchener ('hero of the Sudan') to take command of the British war effort.

This was the real military turning point in the war. Kitchener and Roberts re-organised the supply situation and developed a clear strategy to defeat the Boers. The towns of Kimberly, Ladysmith and Mafeking, the latter town had held out for 217 days, were all relieved in quick succession, producing scenes of jubilation never before seen on the streets of Britain. By June 1900 British forces were moving swiftly towards complete victory. Johannesburg and Pretoria, the capital of the Transvaal, were occupied. Paul Kruger and his government took flight to Europe (Kruger died in exile in 1904).

In the summer of 1900 Britain basked in the glory of its seemingly swift and overwhelming victory over the 'bloody Boers', as they were termed in the popular press. Kitchener and Roberts returned to Britain sure that the war was as good as over. In October 1900 the Unionist government cashed in on the war euphoria by staging the famous 'Khaki Election' and were rewarded with victory over the Liberal Party. Yet these celebrations were premature. The Boer armies had not given up. In fact, they refused to surrender and headed for the countryside to fight one of the most gritty guerilla campaigns ever waged by a small power against a major world power

until the Vietnam War of the 1960s and 1970s.

In 1901 the Boers invaded Cape Colony. Lord Kitchener returned once more to South Africa. He was absolutely determined to deal 'once and for all' with the guerilla tactics of the enemy. The tactics he used were a political blunder and caused enormous controversy. He divided the country into zones and sectioned them off with barbed wire. The idea was to impede the movement of Boer soldiers. In order to prevent the Boer soldiers from replenishing their stocks of food Kitchener introduced a 'scorched earth policy'. This consisted of burning Boer villages, destroying crops, capturing cattle, and collecting the civilian population in something called 'concentration camps'.

3 The Home Front: Radicals against the Boer War

The conditions in these concentration camps created an international outcry and in Britain produced an influential body of organised criticism against the war. This was led by radicals in the Liberal Party, the Labour Party, and among socialists. Henry Campbell-Bannerman, the Liberal leader, summed up the general feeling of the opponents of war in a speech in 1901.

- 1 A phrase is often used that war is war in relation to the conditions in the camps. But, when one asks what is going on in South Africa the government says there is no war, it is a local dispute. So I ask when is a war not a war? When it is carried on with the methods of 5 barbarism now used in South Africa.

This 'methods of barbarism' view dominated the arguments of the organised opponents of the war - the pro-Boers. Many of the opponents took a religious and humanitarian tone. It was Liberal radicals who led the attacks against the war even though the pro-Boers failed to persuade the Liberal Party leadership to back their cause. The Liberal Opposition saw it as their constitutional duty to express loyalty to the policy of the government in time of war. In fact, a large number of leading Liberals - Grey, Haldane, Asquith and Rosebery - were 'Liberal imperialists' who supported the war. The radicals, among whom Lloyd George was numbered, only made up about a third of Liberal MPs.

The pro-Boers concentrated their attacks on the 'jingoistic' Unionist government. They sent the radical Emily Hobhouse to South Africa to produce a report on the conditions in the concentration camps. She revealed that they were surrounded by barbed wire, that 12 prisoners shared a small bell tent, that there was no soap, no toilets, no mattresses, and few blankets, and that rations were below starvation level. She concluded that 'the army have no humanity' and that many soldiers admitted the war was a 'gigantic mistake'. The pro-Boers later sent Joshua Rowntree, a renowned expert on poverty, to report on

conditions, but he was refused entry into the camps.

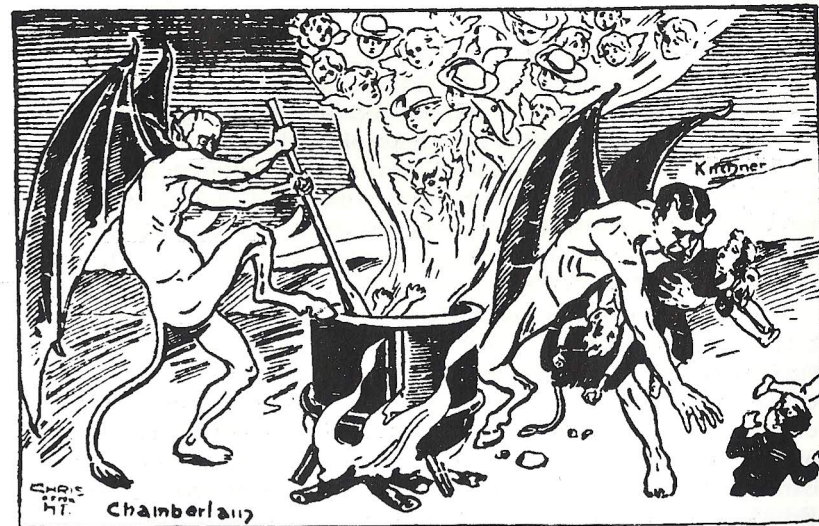
The growing left-wing socialist press went even further in its denunciation of the war, which they argued was being fought by a 'privileged few' for 'capitalist aims'. Here are three typical examples of the views put forward by the socialist press;

a) The war is fought for greedy ghouls who rejoice in the fact that every drop of blood will eventually be turned into gold for themselves.

b) The stock exchange gang have engineered this war so that Britain shall destroy the independence of the Boer Republics and save Rhodesia from bankruptcy.

c) Joseph Chamberlain dragged Britain into this nice little war which is run by an unscrupulous minister [Chamberlain] and an unscrupulous propagandist [Milner].

However, it is clear that the views of the radicals and the socialist press did not reflect a broader public opposition to the war among the working class and in Britain as a whole. H.F. Wyatt, who spoke at numerous anti-Boer War meetings, recorded that there was a 'violent selfishness in the working class areas I visited'. But Wyatt found few working-class people who believed the war was being fought - as the government claimed - to obtain democratic rights for the Uitlanders.



Joseph Chamberlain and Lord Kitchener 'sending the Innocents to Heaven'. This cartoon appeared in a German magazine Ulk (1901)

Even working-class soldiers were sceptical about this. One typical letter from a soldier recorded, 'I don't see the point of it. We are all half starved all the time. It's the worst war ever and all for gold mines'.

The world-wide outrage against the concentration camps was much more pronounced. The war received enormous coverage in the German press. The German Chancellor, Von Bulow, denounced British treatment of Boer prisoners as 'brutal and inhuman.' German newspapers and magazines produced hostile cartoons (see page 95). The general international view of Britain was of 'a bully of women and children, and a very inefficient one at that'. The supposed 'defender of the weak' was in fact doing just the opposite.

At first, the British government refused to accept the claims made about the 'barbaric' concentration camps. It claimed that the camps were 'voluntary' and refused to give details about the number of people who had died in them. To this day no exact figures exist. Numbers as low as 20,000 and as high as 28,000 have been claimed. In 1901 the British government did finally give in to radical pressure for an enquiry. A commission led by Millicent Fawcett, a leading member of the women's suffrage movement, visited the camps and recommended several improvements including more nurses and improved rations. As a result, conditions did improve. Yet the whole affair had been deeply damaging.

4 Peace

Meanwhile, in South Africa the war dragged on. It required 450,000 troops recruited from all over the Empire finally to defeat the Boers. In May 1902 the Boer leaders surrendered at Vereeniging. It had taken over two years for the mighty British Empire to humble a relatively small number of independent-minded farmers. The British lost 22,000 soldiers, 25,000 Boers died and approximately 12,000 Africans were killed. The war had been costly in money as well as lives. As Lloyd George said, 'every shell fired amounted to the cost of a pension for an old person in Britain'.

The peace terms the Boers were offered reflected the general view that the war had been a major blunder. All Afrikaaner prisoners who signed an oath of loyalty to the British crown were freed from the concentration camps. The damage to the Boer farms and villages was enormous. Over 400,000 horses, mules and donkeys perished. As part of the peace settlement, the British agreed to pay the costs of war damage. A total of 63,000 claims were received from Boer farmers. The British also offered loans for re-building, promised to safeguard the Afrikaaner language in any future constitution, and pledged to restore free elections and self-government at the earliest opportunity.

The poet Rudyard Kipling - a strong supporter of imperialism - summed up the public mood in Britain towards the war.

Let us admit it fairly as a business people should
We had no end of a lesson.
It will do us no end of good.

5 The Consequences of the Boer War

a) The Damage to the Unionist Government

The Unionist government which led Britain into the war was damaged by its consequences. Alfred Milner refused to accept the responsibility for what had gone wrong. He put all the blame on the poor planning for war by the government. By 1902 he was writing, 'Why keep an Empire for people who are dead set on chucking it away?'. In 1904 he agreed to demands from the 'Rand' magnates to import Chinese labourers to work in the South African gold mines. This confirmed the radical view that 'the war was fought for the profits of the gold mines' - not the interests of the Uitlanders. When it became known that the Chinese were being flogged for insubordination by the mineowners an outcry followed which led to a vote of censure being tabled against Milner in the House of Commons. The press voiced bitter criticism. The 'Chinese slavery' issue formed a leading part of the Liberal campaign in the 1906 election, but by then Milner had already been recalled by the Liberal government which had taken office in the previous year.

b) The Growth of Anti-Imperialism

The war also led to a definite anti-imperialist group emerging within British politics and society. Before the war the worst motive attributed to supporters of imperialism was excessive patriotism. Imperialism could even be seen as a 'positive mission' designed to bring 'civilisation' to underdeveloped societies. It attracted supporters from all the major political parties. After the war this was no longer the case. Imperialism became synonymous with 'maverick politicians', 'capitalist cliques', and 'methods of barbarism'. As such it became seen as a right-wing policy associated with 'die-hard' Conservatives.

Richard Koebner in 'The Meaning of Imperialism' (*Economic History Review*, 1949) showed how the very meaning of the word imperialism changed from a positive one before the Boer War to a negative one afterwards. J.A. Hobson in his very influential study *Imperialism* (1902) produced a coherent and successful attack on imperialism. Hobson argued that by their actions in the Boer War the imperialists 'had jeopardised the entire wealth of the nation in rousing strong resentment of other nations for no real gain'.

c) The 'Revolution' in British Foreign Policy

The war also brought about a 'a revolution in British foreign relations'. Before the Boer War Britain believed itself strong enough to follow an independent foreign policy. This was popularly known as 'splendid isolation', the most important feature of which was that no military alliances were entered into with other major powers. However, the difficulties experienced during the protracted conflict revealed that the policy was no longer tenable. Soon after the war the policy was abandoned. Britain sought diplomatic agreements with imperial rivals anywhere she could find them. The Anglo-Japanese Alliance (1902), the Anglo-French Entente (1904), and the Anglo-Russian Convention (1907) followed in rapid succession. In addition, differences with the USA over Venezuela were settled and American domination of the North American continent was accepted.

d) The Growth of Anglo-German Antagonism

The war also contributed to the further souring of Anglo-German relations. In 1899 a number of leading members of the Unionist government had been in favour of an Anglo-German agreement. However, the frequent slanging matches which took place between the British and German press and between British and German politicians over the concentration camp scandal made it unlikely that there would be an Anglo-German 'understanding'.

Anglo-German antagonism intensified between 1902 and 1914. Many of the leading British imperialists who had supported the war switched their attention away from problems in Africa and towards those in Europe. It was widely believed that the Boer War had revealed what was described as the 'weakening of the British race'. As a result, imperialists tended to become 'scaremongers', forming themselves into a whole range of military and naval pressure groups, such as the National Service League and the Imperial Maritime League. The Conservative press and periodicals, such as *A Nation at Arms* and *The National Review*, warned of German spies and of possible German invasions. Rifle and military clubs were formed. Baden-Powell, (later Lord Baden Powell), the 'hero of Mafeking', established the Boy Scout and the Girl Guide movements to instil military ideals in children. The emphasis in imperialist literature switched from 'bloody Boers' to a 'wild Kaiser'. The imperialist 'radical right' continued their troublemaking right up to the outbreak of war in 1914. But the focus of their agitation was on the dangers of Germany, Socialism, David Lloyd George, and Home Rule for Ireland. The previous emphasis on 'imperial expansion' was downplayed.

e) The Defence Review of the Edwardian Era

The war led to a major review of British defence. There were full-scale government investigations into military planning, the military needs of the Empire, recruitment, army and navy organisation, food and ammunition supply, and home defence. Even the poor health of working-class recruits (via the Physical Deterioration Committee) for the Boer War was investigated. Army, navy and social reforms soon followed. Free School meals and medical examinations in schools were introduced after 1906. The Haldane Reforms of the Army (1907) led to the creation of a fully equipped British Expeditionary Force (BEF). This was designed to move quickly from Britain into battle overseas. A Territorial Army (TA) of voluntary part-time soldiers designed to protect Britain from invasion was also set up. The Fisher Reforms of the Navy in 1904 led to a greater concentration of naval power in Europe and to the creation of a new fleet of 'unsinkable' battleships known as 'Dreadnoughts'. The Germans responded by building their own versions, and for the first time British naval supremacy was threatened.

f) The End of the *Pax Britannica*

The war also damaged the widely held view that the British Empire spread peace and prosperity around the world. The idea that Britain was the 'world's policeman' who could be called upon in an emergency to defend the 'weak' nations against the ambitions of the strong was deeply discredited. The charge of police brutality was laid against the 'world's policeman'. The high moral tone Britain had struck in its diplomatic relations since the mid-nineteenth century rang hollow after the concentration camps of the Boer War. No longer was Britain in a position to give moral lectures to anybody.

g) The Legacy for South African Politics

In the years after the war what can now be seen as a potentially catastrophic political situation was allowed to develop in South Africa. In 1906 the Liberal government restored self-government and free elections (for white people) to the defeated states. In the 1907 elections the Afrikaner Het Volk Party, which was committed to a Union of South Africa and racial segregation, won a sweeping victory with the support of the newly enfranchised Uitlanders. In 1910 the Orange River Colony, the Transvaal, and Cape Colony agreed to form the Union of South Africa. Louis Botha, one of the leading guerilla leaders who had defied the British during the Boer War, became its first Prime Minister. This Boer-dominated Union, because it was accorded complete self-government, was able to develop a racist state over which Britain



HAIL, KITCHENER! VICTOR AND PEACEMAKER!

Lord Kitchener returns victorious from the Boer War as 'Victor and Peacemaker', Punch cartoon, 9 July 1902

was subsequently able to exercise no control.

h) The Move Towards Dominion Status

The other self-governing colonies (Australia, Canada and New Zealand) also sought a re-definition of their constitutional relationship with Britain in the years following the conflict. They objected to being called 'colonies'. The term implied they were still under the 'control' of Britain. In 1907 the word 'dominion' was used to describe all the self-governing areas of the Empire. An imperial Conference based on the principle 'one government, one vote' was set up to decide future constitutional disputes within the Empire. This meant that the 'dominions' could now outvote Britain on matters related to their own constitutional relationship with the mother country. This was independence in all but name.

6 Assessment: The Boer War as Catalyst?

The Boer War was clearly one of those rare turning points in the history of the Empire between 1815 and 1914. It cast a giant shadow over British attitudes towards the Empire and imperial defence in the period from 1902 to the outbreak of the First World War in 1914. Many contemporaries viewed it as 'the first nail in the coffin of the British Empire'. The historian Zara Steiner believes the Boer war was 'a catalyst' for a number of changes that were going on in the way Britain looked at itself, its Empire and its relations with the world. There are, of course, some historians who would dispute this. C.C. Eldridge, for example, has argued that the British Empire not only survived all the traumas produced by the Boer War but expanded as a result of its victory and became even more important for British trade and investment than it had ever been before. The economic statistics seem to support this interpretation. Between 1903 and 1914 British exports to the Empire increased by 32 per cent, imports from the Empire increased by 31 per cent, British trade with Africa doubled, and 42 per cent of all British overseas investment went to the Empire.

But, of course, the true impact of the Boer war cannot be measured in purely economic terms. Robert Blake has recently described the war as 'Britain's Vietnam'. This comparison is attractive. The difficulty America found in defeating the guerrilla tactics of the Vietcong has similarities with the obstacles Britain faced in overcoming the roaming bands of Boer cavalymen. The bombing of Cambodia, the dropping of napalm, and the burning of Vietnamese villages all damaged America's reputation at home and abroad in the 1960s and early 1970s. As Vietnam marks the end of America's incredible self-confidence as a nation on the world stage in the post-1945 period, so we can see the

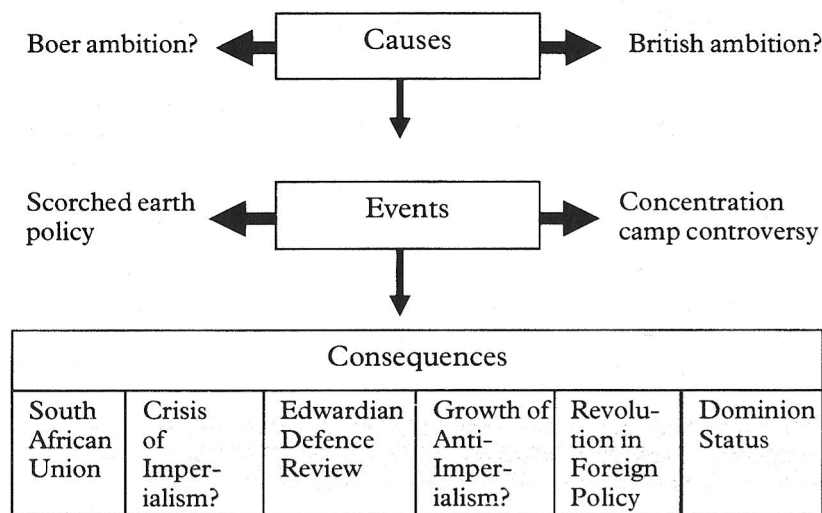
Boer War as having a similar psychological impact on Britain and its image in the world in the years leading to the First World War.

The Boer War really marks the dividing line between the passionate imperialism of late-Victorian England and the loss of self-confidence in Britain about its future that has typified the twentieth century. This loss of confidence may not have been completely warranted. But it was widely felt all the same. The war was the last time that a small colonial war aroused the passions of the British people until the the Falklands campaign in 1982.

After the Boer War the British never believed as strongly as they had before it that the British Empire was one on which the sun would never set. There were many who expressed pessimism about the future. In 1914 the Liberal Colonial Secretary expressed his belief that 'the Empire is held together by a silken cord: twist this cord into a whiplash and a crack of the lash would be the death knell of the Empire'. This shows how much the bungled attempt to teach the Boers a lesson had permeated the British view of its long-term relations with the people of its Empire.

Making notes on 'The Crisis of the Empire, 1895-1914: The Boer War and its Consequences'

This chapter lays particular stress on the causes and the consequences of



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the Boer War. A brief account of the course of the war is also included. It would therefore seem to be a good idea to compile your notes under three headings.

- 1 Causes. Draw up a list of the causes of the war. The roles of Kruger, Milner and Joseph Chamberlain are all important. It would also be worth including mention of the activities of Cecil Rhodes. Indicate the relative importance of each cause you explain.
- 2 Course. Divide the war up into its various stages, explaining the identifying features of each one. List the reasons why the war lasted for so long.
- 3 Consequences. Decide on the relative importance of the consequences. Note them in a descending order of importance.

Answering essay questions on 'The Crisis of the Empire, 1895-1914: The Boer War and its Consequences'

Essay questions on the Boer War normally focus on the causes or the consequences, or both. It is very unlikely that you will be asked to give a chronological narrative of the fighting. The following are typical of the questions set on the Boer War.

- 1 What were the major consequences of the Boer War for Britain?
- 2 Explain the causes and the consequences of the Anglo-Boer War.
- 3 How far can Britain's part in causing the Boer War be justified?
- 4 Comment on the view that 'the Boer War was a blessing in disguise for Britain'.

Questions 1 and 2 are phrased just about as straightforwardly as is possible. The problem with such seemingly 'easy' questions is that every candidate who answers them is likely to produce a 'standard' answer, making it difficult for the examiner to do otherwise than to award a set of similarly mediocre marks. The skill in answering simple questions is to find an approach that allows your essay to stand out in some distinctive way. There are many ways of doing this. The approach that involves least risk of getting into a tangle is to answer the question from different points of view. In these cases the points of view could be those of contemporaries and of later commentators, or of Boers and British. What other points of view could be used to form the structure of an answer?

Questions 3 and 4 are much more challenging, and potentially much more rewarding. Both need to be 'unpacked' in the normal way. Question 3, in particular, opens up very easily once thought has been given to identifying just what is being asked of the candidate. In fact, two questions have been rolled into one. What are they? The second of the questions is about 'justification'. This means making judgements,